

Birthday BASH-UP

An engineer's murder throws light on the unorthodox fundraising methods of India's fastest-growing political party

By Subhash Mishra

Mayawati's birthday that falls on January 15 is celebrated in Uttar Pradesh as "*Aarthik Sahyog Diwas*" (financial assistance day). The celebrations are particularly elaborate when she is in power and quotas are fixed for the party's rank and file—ministers, MPs, and lower level leaders—to fill the coffers. If cajoling fails, extortion does the needful. "The stature of a party worker is fixed on the basis of the amount he brings in," says a senior BSP leader.

The pre-birthday celebrations went awry on the night of December 23 when BSP MLA Shekhar Tiwari barged into the Gas Authority of India Limited guesthouse in Auraiya, about 250 km from Lucknow, and killed 50-year-old Manoj Gupta, an executive engineer with the state PWD who said he couldn't pay up. "My husband was under pressure from Tiwari to cough up a huge amount for Mayawati's birthday," said Shashi Gupta, wife of the deceased engineer. The MLA and his supporters beat him up and as he fell unconscious, they dumped him at the police station. The police took Gupta to the nearest hospital where he was declared dead.

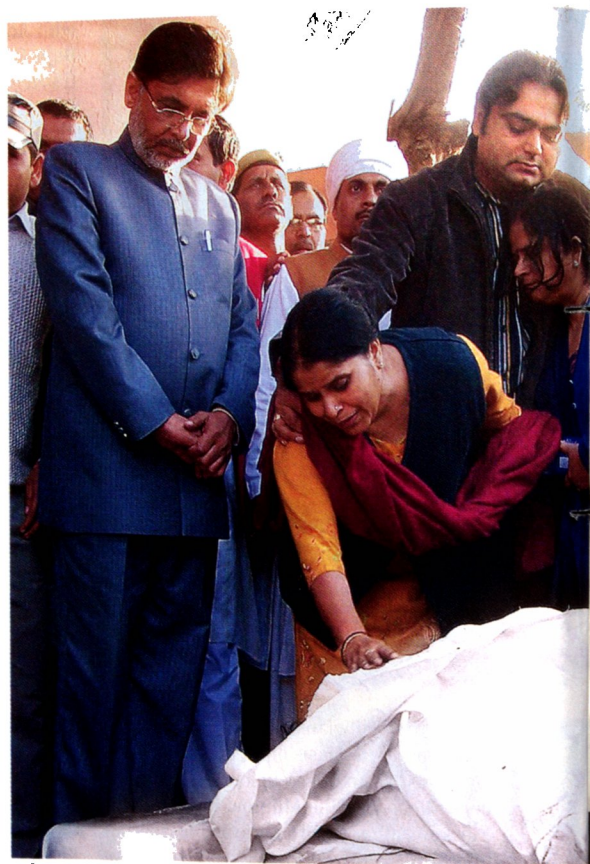
Initially, the district police allegedly tried to hush up the case and

sought to shield the MLA by saying that the injured Gupta was dropped by unknown people at the station after he got involved in a brawl. But the news of the gruesome killing spread like wildfire. Opposition leaders in Auraiya, which adjoins Etawah, hometown of the Samajwadi Party (SP) chief Mulayam Singh Yadav, lost no time in holding Mayawati responsible for Gupta's murder. The chief minister has already been facing serious charges of patronising the criminals and mafia dons in the state to bolster the chances of the BSP candidates in the Lok Sabha elections.

This is not the first time Tiwari's name has figured in a controversy but nobody in the party dared to speak against him because he enjoyed the support of Satish Chandra Mishra, the architect of Mayawati's hugely successful social engineering

doctrine. Amid mounting pressure, the police arrested Tiwari under dramatic circumstances in Kanpur. The efforts of the state Government to pacify the rising tempers of the Opposition and the public failed.

Mayawati came to power in May 2007 on the plank that her first target would be criminals—political and otherwise—who had been holding the state to ransom. Initially she lived up to her words. The most fearsome of the lot—Uma Kant Yadav, Anand Sen Yadav, Jamuna Prasad Nishad, Guddu Sharma—all BSP MPs, ministers and MLAs respectively, were incarcerated on criminal charges. But somewhere along the way, her campaign lost steam. With the Maya magic losing some of its sheen as the Lok Sabha elections draw closer, she found it fit to lure powerful mafia dons into politics. She sent her cabinet min-



MANEESH AGRAWAL